

Marxist Literary Criticism

“The Marxist Lens”

Critical Theory

- How much money do you have, in general terms?
- What “class” do you consider yourself?
- How do your financial means influence your opportunities in life?
- What opportunities/challenges do you have if you are “rich?”
- What opportunities/challenges do you have if you are “poor?”

Pre-Think-It

- One way of deriving the more abstract or meaningful points of a piece of literature is to look at specific aspects of the text that reveal something below the surface of the literal story.
- We refer to these approaches as “Literary Lenses.”
- Like putting on a pair of colored glasses that makes everything shades of one color, literary lenses make us focus on one aspect of the text to examine.

The Literary Lens

Economic Determinist/Marxist Criticism

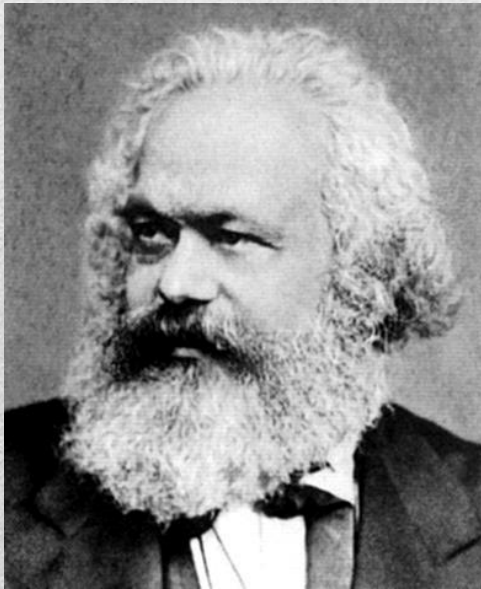
- Karl Marx (1818-1883) emphasized that the primary influence on life was economic, and he saw society as an opposition between the capitalists and the working class.
- Our concepts of class division come from this theory, as well as the likely outcomes of any “class struggle”



- Emphasize the role of **class** (social and economic standing) and **ideology** (main underlying principles) as they reflect, promote, and sometimes challenge the prevailing social order. They often focus how those in power seek to maintain that power, in part by justifying it through art and literature. They also focus on the struggle that exists between the working class and the ruling (elite) class.

Marxist Criticism

NOTE: Marxist Literary Criticism



Does not support Marxist communism or socialism. This is simply a way of reading and interpreting art. Think of this as a lens to look through & see better.

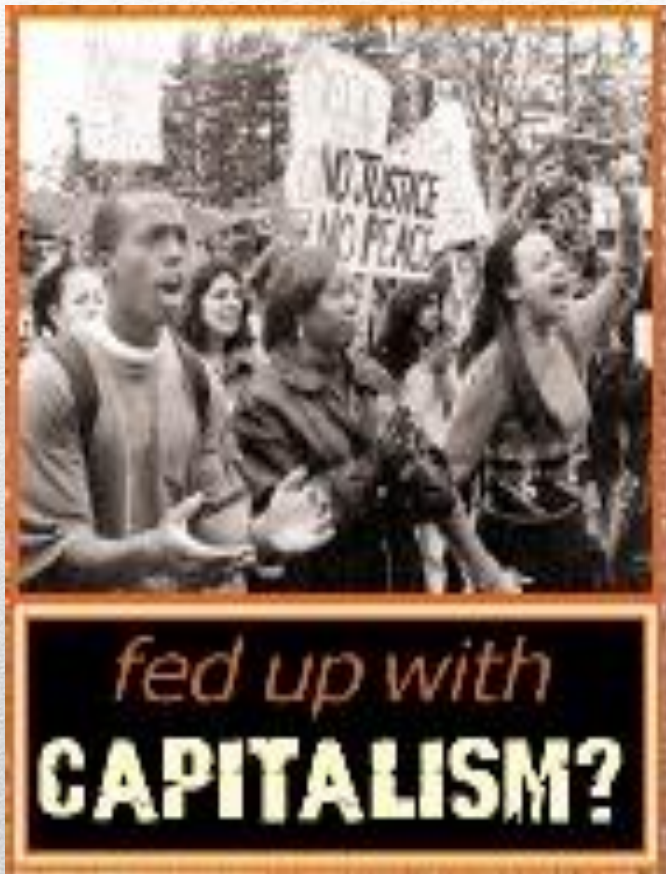
- (1) Make a division between the “overt” (manifest or surface) and “covert” (latent or hidden) content of a literary work
- (2) Examines the social classes of characters and how they interact and/or where the power/control lies
- (3) Relate the context of a work to the social-class status of the author

What Marxist critics do:

- (4) Relate the literary work to the social assumptions of the time in which it is “consumed” (or read)
- (5) Look for symbols that create or reveal an
 - “individual versus exploitive system” theme
 - “oppressive culture” theme
 - “individual as dehumanized, mechanized, roboticized, zombieified—only serving the larger cause; only producing for ‘greater good’” theme

What Marxist critics do:

Economic Determinist/Marxist Criticism



- **The literature that emerged from this kind of analysis focuses on individuals in the grips of a class struggle.**
 - **It emphasizes persons of the lower class and their constant oppression by the upper class.**
 - **The poor may try to escape their situation but ultimately fall back under the ruthless dominion of the capitalist oppressor.**
-

- **These critics also examined how ideology (basic beliefs and values) related to Hegemony – or the pervasive system of assumptions that shapes the perception of reality for people in a culture. In other words, how does a controlling class convince the working class that their way of life is in their best interest?**

Marxism and Hegemony

- 1. What is the economic situation of the characters, and what happens to them as a result of this status?**
- 2. To what extent are the lives of characters influenced or determined by social (i.e. how an individual is expected to behave in a given circumstance), political (i.e. the directives of the state), and economic (i.e. the interplay between production, supply, and demand) forces?**
- 3. What social forces and institutions are represented in the work?**
- 4. To what extent does the work overlook the economic, social, and political implications of its material?**

Economic Determinist/Marxist
Critical Questions

- **On a word document**
- **Pick a story or movie you are familiar with.**
- **Examine the class structure/interactions within or inherent to the work and explain the results of them.**
- **Fill an entire half page with your analysis.**

Practice!

- For the following video, write a half page response. Focus on the following questions:
- How is the power of capital portrayed?
- How is class divided and what roles do each of the classes play in the story?
- What route to power is available to the lower classes?
- How do the upper classes seek to maintain their status or use their power to suppress the lower classes?
- What does the ending tell you about class conflict and how it “should” be resolved?

Bob's Burgers

- Write a one-page analysis of the Marxist elements and concerns in Guy de Maupassant's "The Necklace." Use the following questions to guide your response:
- Who has money and who doesn't? How does that affect the relationship?
- What is the cost of a lost object to a poor person?
- What does the rich person do to maintain their status?
- What does money and status look like to each of the characters?
- Where can you see the ambitions of the lower classes?

"The Necklace"